

Figure 3: Privileges management

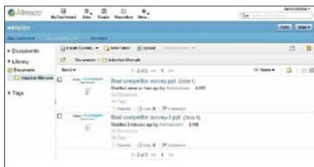


Figure 4: Automatic document versioning

Alfresco also has version control for documents; it automatically shows edited documents with versions (Figure 4). Hence, you don't have to bother about parallel changes to the same file. Alfresco even allows you to have an exclusive lock on the files, so that only one person can edit the file at a single time. Once you're done and check in the document, it becomes available to others for editing.

Alfresco document management also allows tags to be associated with the documents, which makes it easy to search and identify them.

User management

Alfresco offers a robust user management system with efficient handling of users and privileges. It also supports social networking, allowing users to set their status, and also 'like' and comment on events. This adds great value, bringing the team closer. To add a user, visit the 'More' link in the admin dashboard, then the 'Users' link to get to the 'Users' page (Figure 5). Once users are created, you can invite them to any Alfresco site you have created; and while inviting them, you can set the users' roles. This allows a great deal of flexibility, since you can have a user with different roles on different sites. Similarly, a group can be added instead of a user, and a whole group can be invited at once to a site, making the whole process a lot faster.

Workflows

Alfresco supports workflows also. You can create workflows for any task you wish. Just go to the admin/user dashboard and select 'Start Workflow' in the 'My Tasks' window (Figure



Figure 5: User management



Figure 6: Adding users



Figure 7: Workflow

7). A workflow can be of five types, and these pretty much cover real-world scenarios. Once you select a type, you get a form to fill, and you are done. Workflows also allow you to add documents to them. Thus you can send a file for approval, review, and almost anything you can think of. You can even start a workflow by selecting a document and then clicking the 'Start Workflow' link.

As we have seen, Alfresco has probably all the features to make it an ideal enterprise content management software, and we should have no qualms in claiming it as a suitable open source alternative for SharePoint. I am sure that once you start exploring it, you will realise that whatever I have discussed in this article is just the tip of the iceberg—the best awaits you. I hope you find this article useful, and it serves you in some way. Any questions are most welcome. **END** 

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